Testimony from senior Indian military officers involved in the crisis supports this view. For example, Satish Nambiar, India's deputy director general of military operations in 1990, states that the "usual indicators of impending conflict, such as the dumping of ammunition and the laying of mines, were not seen" during the standoff. And since the Indian government did not want to take provocative actions "even in a cautionary manner," any aggressive "low-level moves at the command level were stopped by higher authority." Nambiar "never got the sense that the Indian political leadership wanted to escalate" the 1990 standoff.[41]

Senior Indian civilian officials hold similar views. For example, S. K. Singh, Indian foreign secretary during the crisis, characterizes the claim that India and Pakistan were on the brink of war in 1990 as "a fairy tale" and describes the standoff as "an elephantine non-crisis." According to Singh, the idea of attacking Pakistan "did not cross anyone's mind in the Indian policy-making community anytime during those weeks."[42] Pakistani leaders evince similar views regarding Indian intentions. According to Benazir Bhutto, the Pakistan government did not believe that the Indians were planning to attack. "I believe the 1990 crisis was just overblown," she explains. "We never looked upon the threat as a serious threat from India. . . . It never was any danger point."[43]

Substantial evidence indicates that Indian leaders did not wish to strike Pakistan during the 1990 crisis. While this evidence does not prove that Pakistani nuclear weapons did not deter India from attacking Pakistan during the standoff, it strongly suggests that, as Chari, Cheema, and Cohen argue, "neither India nor Pakistan *wanted* to go to war in early 1990, despite the fact that the tension level between them had risen to an alarmingly high level."[44] Thus we should not consider Pakistani nuclear weapons to have deterred India from launching a war during the 1990 crisis.

Nuclear weapons did, however, play a significant role in triggering the 1990 crisis. The standoff arose out of India's attempt to force Pakistan to cease its support for separatists fighting Indian rule in Kashmir. The Pakistanis' willingness to provide the insurgency with extensive material support resulted to a great extent from the emboldening effects of its burgeoning nuclear capacity, which